GRAMMAR 3: SENTENCE STRUCTURE

The simplest sentence structure consists of one clause which contains a subject (the doer of the action; topic or idea being focused on) and a verb (what the doer does; what is being said about the subject). Look at the examples below:

Example 1	The sun	shines.
	Subject	Verb
Example 2	Victor	laughed.
	Subject	Verb

A more complicated sentence may have more clauses.

Example:	The sun	shines,	and	the wind	blows.
	Subject	Verb		Subject	Verb

Elements of a Clause and Sentence

The basic elements of a clause are **subject (S)**, **verb (V)**, **object (O)**, **complement (C)**, and **adverbial (A)**. Note that **O**, **C**, and **A** are **optional**. In other words, they do not occur in every clause. The table below explains these basic elements.

Elements	Definition	Explanation and Examples
Subject	▪ Doer of the action; ▪ Topic or idea being focused on	▪ Must be a **noun/pronoun** or a **group of words functioning as a noun** ▪ ***John*** found the lost book.
Verb	▪ Action done by the subject	▪ Must be a **verb** ▪ Many people ***witnessed*** the accident.
Object	▪ Person or thing affected by the action or situation	▪ Must be a **noun/pronoun** or a **group of words functioning as a noun** ▪ The manager wrote ***a good report***.
Complement	▪ Additional information about the subject or object ▪ A **subject complement (SC)** gives additional information about the subject and often comes after such verbs as *be*, *become*, *look* and *seem*. ▪ An **object complement (OC)** gives more information about the state or quality of the object.	▪ Must be a **noun/pronoun** or **adjective** or **groups of words functioning as a noun/adjective** ▪ She is ***the winner***. ▪ The weather has become ***colder.*** ▪ He called the lawyer ***a liar***. ▪ They made the house ***beautiful.***
Adverbial	▪ An adverb, or a group of words behaving like an adverb, which gives more information about *how*, *when*, *where*, *why* an action is performed	▪ Must be an **adverb**, or a **group of words behaving like an adverb** ▪ He spoke ***loudly***. ▪ It rained ***steadily yesterday***.

Basic Clause/Sentence Patterns

The elements of a clause are put together to form different patterns. There are five basic simple clause/sentence patterns in English.

Patterns	Structure	Examples
1	Subject + Verb (S + V)	The sun shines. **S** **V**
2	Subject + Verb + Subject Complement (S + V + SC)	This book is useful. **S** **V** **SC**
3	Subject + Verb + Object (S + V + O)	We conducted the experiment. **S** **V** **O**
4	Subject + Verb + Object + Object Complement (S + V + O + OC)	She told him to leave. **S** **V** **O** **OC**
5	Subject + Verb + Adverb (S + V + A)	The child cried loudly. **S** **V** **A**

Kinds of Clauses

There are two main kinds of clauses: **independent** and **dependent**.

An **independent clause** contains a subject and a verb, and it expresses a complete idea. In other words, it can stand by itself. Look at the examples below.

1) He won the race.
2) Learning a second language is difficult.
3) Tomorrow is a holiday.

Even though a **dependent clause** also contains a subject and a verb, it **does not express a complete idea**. It "depends" on another clause to complete its meaning. Another way of understanding a dependent clause is that it **adds information to another clause**. Dependent clauses begin with a word that shows what kind of information is being added. Look at the examples below.

1) Because he had a good strategy…
2) If you live in your own country…
3) Whom you vote for…
4) When it happens…

Exercise 1: Distinguishing between Independent and Dependent Clauses

Read each clause below carefully. If it is an independent clause, write "I" on the space provided; if it is a dependent clause, write "D".

1) Many people voted for him. _____
2) Since I was a child. _____
3) Many kinds of services are available online. _____
4) While you were sleeping. _____
5) But it can be repaired. _____
6) Technology has changed our lives. _____
7) To whom I am speaking. _____
8) Although the economy is improving. _____
9) Because eating too much sugar is bad for you. _____
10) The earth's temperature has risen. _____

Kinds of Sentences

Based on the number of clauses they contain, sentences can be grouped into three types: simple, compound and complex.

A **simple sentence** contains one independent clause.

1) He slept early.
2) He woke up at 7 am.

A **compound sentence** consists of two or more independent clauses which are joined by a coordinating conjunction (*and, or, but*) and a comma or which are joined by a semicolon.

1) He slept early, and he woke up at 7 am.
2) He slept early; he woke up at 7 am.

A **complex sentence** consists of one independent clause and one or more dependent clauses.

1) After finishing his homework, he slept early.
2) When he heard the alarm, he woke up.

Common Errors in Clauses and Sentences

Fragment

A fragment is an incomplete sentence and, therefore, an ungrammatical structure. It is either an incomplete clause or a dependent clause that ends with a full stop. While an incomplete clause has to be completed by adding the subject or verb, a dependent clause has to be joined to an independent clause to make a complete/meaningful sentence. Look at the sentence pairs below: "A" is a fragment, while "B" has been corrected.

A. Working far into the night to finish her assignment.
B. She worked far into the night to finish her assignment.

A. The experiment was rescheduled. Because the equipment and materials were not delivered on time.
B. The experiment was rescheduled because the equipment and materials were not delivered on time.

A. Since my country declared her independence in 1965. We have experienced significant economic development.
B. Since my country declared her independence in 1965, we have experienced significant economic development.

Run-on Sentence/Comma Splice

In a compound sentence (there are two or more independent clauses), the clauses have to be joined together properly using a conjunction (*and, or, but, etc.*) and a comma or a semicolon. Look at the illustrations below. A1 (run-on sentence) and A2 (comma splice) are incorrect; B, C and D show how these sentences can be repaired.

A1. He worked hard he failed to meet his deadline.
B. He worked hard, but he failed to meet his deadline.
C. He worked hard; he failed to meet his deadline.
D. He worked hard. He failed to meet his deadline.

A2. The city is lively, the restaurants are still open.
B. The city is lively, and the restaurants are still open.
C. The city is lively; the restaurants are still open.
D. The city is lively. The restaurants are still open.

Exercise 2: Correcting Fragments and Run-on Sentences

The following sentences are either run-on sentences or sentence fragments. Revise each sentence to make it grammatical. Write your revised sentence in the space provided.

1) It is difficult for people to live in harmony they come from different cultural backgrounds.

_____

_____

2) We should always get as much information about a place. If we plan to study or work there.

_____

_____

3) It is very important to have a healthy lifestyle, we need to eat vegetables and exercise more often.

_____

_____

4) Buying medicine from online pharmacies.

_____

_____

5) People go to the healthcare provider. Since they can afford it.

_____

_____

More about Dependent Clauses

In a complex sentence, dependent clauses can function as adjectives, nouns, or adverbs. See the examples below.

Adjective Clauses (or Relative Clauses):

Like an adjective, this dependent clause describes a noun or a pronoun, and it usually begins with either a relative pronoun (*who, whom, which*, or *that*) or a relative adverb (*where* or *when*). See the examples below.

1) The building that is on the corner belongs to the bank.
2) Rice is a cereal which is eaten in many parts of the world.
3) He married the girl who lived next door.
4) They found the place where the conference was being held.

Note that in some, not all, relative clauses, it is possible to shorten the relative clause by deleting the relative pronoun and the verb "to be." Look at the examples below:

A. The building that is on the corner belongs to the bank.
B. The building on the corner belongs to the bank.

A. Rice is a cereal which is eaten in many countries.
B. Rice is a cereal eaten in many countries.

To be safe, it is better to keep the relative pronoun and the verb "to be" in your relative clause.

Noun Clauses:

Like a noun, this dependent clause can be either the subject of a sentence or the object of a verb. It usually begins with a *wh*-question word, *that*, *whether* or *if*. See the examples below.

1) Nobody knows when the economy will recover. (object)
2) The researchers say that more funds are needed to continue their project. (object)
3) Whether or not this drug will cure cancer is still a big question. (subject)

Adverb Clauses:

Like an adverb, this dependent clause modifies (or adds information) to a verb, adjective or another adverb. An adverb or adverbial clause begins with a subordinating conjunction, such as *although*, *when*, *while*, *because*, *if*, etc. This kind of clause can be put before or after the independent clause. If it is before the independent clause, it is followed by a comma; if it is after the independent clause, no comma is needed. See the examples below.

1) Although there are many hostels on campus, graduate students still find it hard to find accommodation there.
2) Prof. Tan cancelled his class because he fell sick.
3) You should exercise in the morning when you are full of energy.
4) If you finish your work early, you can come to the party.

Connecting Clauses within a Sentence

The two or more clauses in complex and compound sentences must be **connected both grammatically and meaningfully**; that is, the sentence should make sense.

Exercise 3: Correcting Dependent Clause Problems

The following sentences have errors. Correct each sentence.

1. The people whom I have met them in my class are friendly.

   _____

   _____

2. Although Henry hates spinach, but he eats it anyway.

   _____

   _____

3. She got a job so quickly is amazing.

   _____

4. What the results show that was interesting.

   _____

   _____

5. Many travelers fly business class, because of they like the wider seats.

   _____

   _____

6. Loneliness is common among students come to Singapore from other countries.

   _____

   _____

Adapted from:

Macmillan Publishers Ltd. (2012). *One Stop English*. Retrieved July 10, 2012 from www.onestopenglish.com
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